As we already know, 4 Garhwal had been ordered to fall back from Nuranang as it was felt that the covering troops were meant to act as a delaying force as per the Indian Army tactical manual. Yet, in the overall scheme of things, this seemed to be an ad hoc decision, for there were no clear cut defences for it to occupy, either at Se-la Top or at Senge.

If 62 Infantry Brigade had to take the fight to the Chinese, it was imperative for each man, section, platoon, company, battalion to know what was expected of him and their exact position in battle. Equally critical would have been the interdependence and coordination between the battalions. The commander and the commanding officers on the Se-la massif on 17 November did not have to be master strategists to understand this single basic fact; and yet, in the three weeks that were available to them, not once were counter-attacks or strategic withdrawals discussed, let alone practised. 4 Garhwal Rifles, pulling back from Nuranang after the day's fighting, would have expected to occupy preordained defences at Se-la Top. Instead, only once the battalion got there, did it dawn on the officers that there were no defences to occupy. The redeployment of the 'covering troops' had simply not been given any thought!

The 4 Garhwal withdrawal began as per Hoshiar Singh's instructions and the battalion, exhausted after a day's hard fighting and the withdrawal, reached Se-la Top at 3 a.m. Instead of redeploying in prepared defences, the battalion was told to carry on marching towards Senge Dzong. Meanwhile, quite a few stragglers had fallen behind and they were by then much too tired to push on. About fifty men decided to take a break and began brewing tea when the rearguard of the artillery appeared. The battery commander told the men to get moving as the Chinese were hot on their heels, but the men were too fatigued to move.

The Chinese caught the straggler party and mowed them all down. 4 Garhwal, which in the entire day's battle had lost two men, now had more than half a company's worth killed without even the semblance of a fight. The ruthless execution of the Garhwalis out in the open was a clear indication of the Chinese intention to kill as many Indian troops as possible with a view towards completely annihilating 4 Division.

At the time the Garhwali stragglers were being butchered by the Chinese advance elements, half of 62 Brigade was on the move; 4 Garhwal Rifles was marching on towards Senge, 4 Sikh LI after having covered the withdrawal of the main body of Garhwalis and the artillery guns was now